

The Cave of Crystals

A horseshoe-shaped underground cavern in Mexico containing some of the most enormous natural crystals ever discovered



The Cave of Crystals lies 980 ft (300 m) below a mountain at Naica in northern Mexico. In April 2000, workers at the Naica Mine were excavating a new tunnel when they discovered the Cave of Crystals. The chamber is filled with gigantic, beamlike crystals of the mineral selenite.

Birth of giants

The cave, which has been eroded out of the limestone that forms much of Naica Mountain, has existed for several thousand years. At some point after its formation, when it was flooded with water, mineral-rich groundwater rising from below came into contact with cooler, oxygen-rich surface water in the vicinity of the cave. The oxygen diffused into the groundwater, causing

The cave's **largest crystal is 39 ft (12 m) long and weighs 55 tons (50 tonnes)**

the selenite to be deposited in the form of crystals. This continued at an extremely slow rate for at least 500,000 years, forming the gigantic crystals that exist today.

Terra incognita

The cave is relatively unexplored because of its depth and the continued presence of heated water below the surface. Air temperatures can reach 136°F (58°C), and at present, the cave lacks public access.



△ GYPSUM TROVE

The crystal reserves found within the Cave of Crystals are made of selenite. A variety of gypsum, selenite is a soft, light-colored mineral containing calcium sulfate and water.

◁ CRYSTAL FOREST

The Cave of Crystals in Mexico houses some of the largest natural crystals ever found. Here, massive beams of selenite dwarf explorers in the cavern.



LOCATION OF THE CAVE OF CRYSTALS

Naica Mountain has several caverns, including the Cave of Crystals. Some of these can be explored only because the Naica Mine Company pumps water out of the ground to keep the water level down.

